Datu Amai Pakpak

Datu Amai Pakpak (died March 10, 1895), also known as **Datu Akadir Akobar**, was a Maranao military leader and chieftain from Lanao who led the resistance against Spanish colonization in the 1890s. He is best remembered for defending Kota Marawi (Fort Marawi) during the two Battles of Marawi in 1891 and 1895, a stand that made him one of the most celebrated heroes of the Maranao people.

He was a native of Marawi who rose to become the principal defender of the Lanao region against Spanish military expeditions in the closing years of the 19th century. His leadership in the two major Battles of Marawi, first against Governor-General Valeriano Weyler's forces in 1891 and again against Governor-General Ramón Blanco's much larger expedition in 1895, cemented his place in Philippine history as a symbol of Moro resistance and Maranao sovereignty. He died in combat on March 10, 1895, during the second Battle of Marawi.

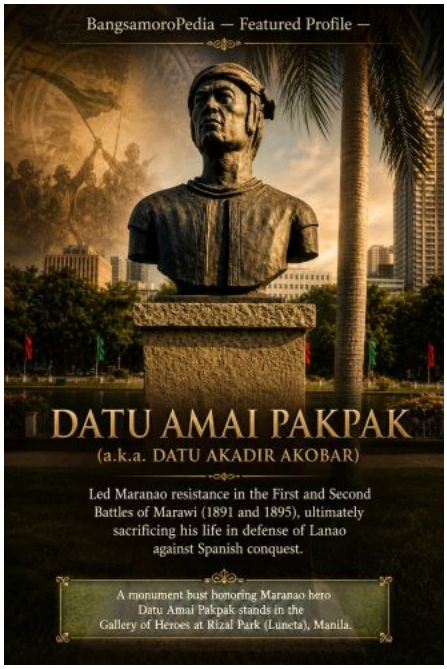
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Early Life and Background

Datu Amai Pakpak was born in Buadi sa Kayo, Marawi, in what is now Lanao del Sur. His given name was Akadir Akobar, though he became known among the Maranao as Amai Pakpak, which translates to "father of Pakpak," a name taken from his daughter. As a datu, he held authority over his community and carried the responsibility of its defense and welfare, a role that would define the rest of his life.

Datu Amai Pakpak



Born

Buadi sa Kayo, Marawi (present-day Lanao del Sur)

Died

March 10, 1895, Kota Marawi, Lanao

Other Names

Datu Akadir Akobar

Title

Datu (Chieftain) of Marawi, Lanao

Notability

Principal defender of Kota Marawi against two major Spanish expeditions, one of the most celebrated military leaders of the 317-year Moro-Spanish War

Known For

Leading Maranao resistance in the First and Second Battles of Marawi (1891 and 1895), giving his life defending Lanao from colonial conquest

Pull Quote

"His body was never identified, as fellow Maranao concealed his identity out of pity and respect."

Military Leadership

Amai Pakpak maintained and commanded a fortification known as Fort Marawi or Kota Marawi, built near the northern shore of Lake Lanao, close to what is now the site of the Agus 2 hydroelectric dam and Camp Amai Pakpak. This earth-and-stone kota stood as the primary line of defense against Spanish incursions into the Lanao region, and it was here that Amai Pakpak would make his stand, twice, against forces that far outnumbered his own.

First Battle of Marawi (1891)

The first major confrontation came on August 21, 1891, when Spanish forces under Governor-General Valeriano Weyler launched an expedition against the Maranao. The Spanish force, numbering around 1,242 soldiers, arrived in Iligan aboard the warships Manila, Cebu, San Quintin, and Marquez de Duero before pushing on toward Kota Marawi.

Under Amai Pakpak's leadership, the Maranao defenders put up a fierce resistance. The Spaniards eventually managed to burn the kota after a two-hour siege, but they withdrew back to Iligan, wary of Maranao reinforcements arriving by vinta, the traditional boats used across Lake Lanao. Amai Pakpak and his warriors wasted no time rebuilding the fortification, bracing for the attack they knew would come again.

Second Battle of Marawi (1895)

Four years later, on March 10, 1895, Governor-General Ramón Blanco returned, this time with a force of over 5,000 soldiers and four gunboats hauled all the way to Lake Lanao. It was a far better equipped expedition, and Spain was determined to finally secure its conquest of Lanao.

The Maranao warriors, once again under Amai Pakpak, mounted a determined defense of Kota Marawi. Despite fierce resistance that slowed the Spanish advance, the fort was eventually overrun. Amai Pakpak, his son Anggay, and 23 other datus perished inside the kota that day. According to some accounts, Amai Pakpak and his son had escaped into a secret chamber (digo-digo) within the fort before launching one final, suicidal attack against the Spanish, in which the datu was killed. His body was never identified, as fellow Maranao concealed his identity out of pity and respect.

The Spanish would eventually withdraw from Lanao following the outbreak of the Spanish–American War in 1898, never having fully conquered the region.

Resistance Against Colonization

Datu Amai Pakpak's resistance against Spanish forces stands as one of the most significant episodes of Moro defiance during the 317-year Moro-Spanish War. His leadership helped preserve Maranao sovereignty and Islamic traditions at a time of intense colonial pressure. The Battles of Marawi in 1891 and 1895 are counted among the largest battles for independence fought before the Philippine Revolution broke out in 1896.

Bangsamoro Context

Amai Pakpak's struggle is woven into the fabric of Bangsamoro history and identity. The National Historical Commission of the Philippines (NHCP) and the Bangsamoro Commission for the Preservation of Cultural Heritage (BCPCH) have both recognized his contributions as part of the wider story of Bangsamoro resistance and nation-building. In August 2024, historical markers honoring Amai Pakpak and the defense of Marawi were unveiled in Marawi City, affirming the Meranaw people's place in Philippine history.

Honors and Recognition

Datu Amai Pakpak is widely regarded as a Maranao hero and a symbol of Moro resistance against foreign colonization. In 1970, the Lanao General Hospital was renamed the Amai Pakpak Medical Center in his honor.

Several institutions and places in Marawi still carry his name today, including:

- Amai Pakpak Medical Center
- Amai Pakpak Central Elementary School
- Amai Pakpak Avenue
- Camp Amai Pakpak (formerly Camp Keithley), the military reservation that now occupies the ground where his kota once stood

Historical Markers

In August 2024, the NHCP and BCPCH unveiled four historical markers in Marawi City: one for "Amai Pakpak," one for "Pagtatanggol sa Marawi" (Defense of Marawi), one for "Labanan sa Marawi" (Battle of Marawi), and one for "Kota Marawi." These were installed at the Lanao People's Park and Public Library, Amai Pakpak Central Elementary School, and Marawi City Hall.

NHCP Chairperson Regalado Trota Jose, Jr. noted that the markers stand as proof of the significant role the Meranaw people played in Philippine social history and nation-building. BCPCH Chairperson Salem Y. Lingasa added that recognizing the contributions of the Meranaw and Bangsamoro is part of correcting long-standing historical injustices.

See Also

- Battle of Marawi (1891)
- Battle of Marawi (1895)
- Kota Marawi
- Maranao people
- Bangsamoro resistance movements
- Valeriano Weyler
- Ramón Blanco
- Amai Pakpak Medical Center
- Camp Amai Pakpak
- National Historical Commission of the Philippines (NHCP)
- Bangsamoro Commission for the Preservation of Cultural Heritage (BCPCH)

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